

Thinking & Research Journal

Mews Corporate Long-Stay Network — How we got here

Companion document to the project pitch and presentation

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Why this journal exists

The take-home brief asks for the thinking and research behind the proposal, not just the conclusion. This document is that work. It's the messy middle — the framings we tried, the ones we turned off, the tradeoffs we navigated, and the load-bearing assumptions that survived.

The conclusion (Mews Corporate Long-Stay Network as a brokerage built on a Resident Platform substrate) reads as obvious in retrospect. It wasn't. The thinking iterated through three significantly different framings before landing here, and each iteration tightened a real constraint that the final answer respects.

Framing 1 — Broker-first marketplace

The first instinct was to build straight to the brokerage: a corporate housing marketplace where buyers (staffing agencies, mobility teams) search Mews properties and contract for long stays. The headline pitch: "Mews becomes the corporate housing broker for the 28+ night segment."

Why it was attractive: It maps cleanly to a Director-level mandate. It's category-defining. It monetizes the unique B2B demand flow that Mews's existing PMS doesn't capture. It rides the Sonder-collapse narrative and the chain land-grab moment. And the JD itself frames Long Stays as needing significant net-new investment.

Why we turned it off (in this form)

Building a marketplace on top of a PMS that current customers like Boost Society and Revisn have already had to engineer around is asking customers to trust the next layer before the foundation is solid. The brokerage adds new demand on top, but the underlying property-side operational gaps (room reassignment on extension, split bill rates, AR reconciliation post-issue) would still be unresolved. Existing customers experience the brokerage as ungrounded promise; the PMS gaps stay; the value proposition reads as net-new product, not platform deepening.

The turn-off moment was the recognition that a marketplace doesn't fix what's already broken; it adds new commitments to a base that customers are visibly maintaining custom code around. That's not a credibility position for an interview pitch.

Framing 2 — Resident Platform substrate only

The reaction was to swing the other direction: focus on the Resident Platform substrate (Resident and Lease as first-class objects in Mews) and defer the marketplace. The pitch becomes: "Mews builds the long-stay platform substrate that closes Boost-style gaps for every existing customer, with the marketplace as a follow-on."

Why it was attractive: It addresses the load-bearing complaint from existing customers. It's defensible technically (façade pattern, no core PMS refactor). It serves the existing book of business. The validation plan writes itself (customer interviews at Revisn and Boost almost certainly confirm the demand).

Why we turned it off (in this form)

*Substrate-only loses the higher-level vision expected of a director. The pitch becomes "deepen what we have" rather than "build something category-defining." Mews can ship Resident Platform without a Director hire; they need the Director-level pitch to be about the **strategic** bet, not the engineering catch-up. And the brokerage opportunity is genuinely time-sensitive — Sonder's collapse and the chain land-grab are happening now. Defer the marketplace 18-24 months and we miss the window.*

Substrate-only is a Senior Manager-level pitch. We needed Director-level.

Framing 3 — Brokerage as headline, substrate as foundation, simultaneous build

The third framing — the one we kept — recognizes that the two prior framings posed a false choice. The brokerage is the headline (Director-level vision, market opportunity, time-sensitive). The substrate is the foundation (existing customer credibility, PMS gap-closing). They are not separable into phases; they are dependencies in a single 12-month bet.

The PMS substrate is what makes the brokerage credible. The brokerage is what makes the substrate strategically interesting. Building them together — Tier 1 universal substrate that all existing customers benefit from, Tier 2 Network brokerage that opted-in properties access for incremental demand — is the only construction that hits both the existing-customer value proposition and the new-market growth bet simultaneously.

The framing that survived

In the next 12 months, Mews should instantiate itself as the corporate housing brokerage for the 28+ night segment, by building a Resident Platform substrate that closes long-stay PMS gaps for every existing customer running 28+ night stays (Tier 1, universal), and adds new product surfaces — corporate booker portal, property network view, mediated three-way contract view, dedicated long-stay booking engine, and resident web portal — that together compose Mews Corporate Long-Stay Network 1.0 (Tier 2, opt-in). The platform investment serves existing customers regardless of Network participation; the Network adds incremental B2B corporate housing demand for the properties that opt in.

Threads explored and turned off

Each of these was seriously considered for some portion of the thinking, then turned off. Documenting them is important because each turn-off respects a constraint the final framing now embeds.

Thread: Hard 90-night cap on segment

What we considered: Defining the segment as 28-90 nights, anchored on Germany's 90-day Boardinghouse limit.

Why we turned it off: 90 nights is one jurisdiction's hospitality/tenancy line. Other markets are more permissive: France's Bail mobilité runs up to 10 months; US and UK corporate-let leases between two companies sit outside individual tenancy law regardless of length. A hard 90-night cap artificially excludes meaningful broker-addressable demand (travel nurses on 13→26 week extensions, project workforce on 90-180 day deployments, corporate assignees on 6-12 month placements).

How the final framing handles it: Lower bound is 28+ nights. No hard upper bound for v1. The cap is whatever the local jurisdiction permits as a hospitality / non-tenancy operating model — explicitly jurisdiction-specific and contract-structure-specific.

Thread: B2C demand in the marketplace

What we considered: Opening the Network marketplace to individual consumer demand (digital nomads, leisure long-stay travelers, individual travel nurses booking direct).

Why we turned it off: The economics don't work for B2C through a broker model. A 5-7% take rate on a \$15K/month corporate booking is worth running a marketplace for; the same percentage on a \$1.8K individual booking is not, especially once you add customer support burden. B2C demand for long stays is already served by direct property channels, OTAs, and consumer-facing platforms; a broker adds no value where the consumer is doing their own discovery.

How the final framing handles it: The Network marketplace is B2B-only for 1.0. B2C long-stay demand is served by a separate product surface — the long-stay booking engine (Tier 1) at the property level — where Mews captures subscription + Mews Payments revenue without imposing brokerage take rate.

Thread: Mid-term rental operators as supply universe

What we considered: Including residential mid-term rental operators (Blueground, Anyplace, Furnished Finder hosts) as supply addressable by Mews.

Why we turned it off: They operate on a completely different software stack — residential property management software (AppFolio, Buildium, Hostfully) — and a different operating license. They're

competitors at the demand level (the buyer doesn't care which type of operator fulfills the booking), but they're not Mews's natural supply universe. Trying to onboard them would require either (a) Mews building a residential PMS, which is a multi-year strategic detour, or (b) an integration play with their existing PMSs, which is partner-dependent and slow.

How the final framing handles it: Mews-addressable supply is explicitly limited to extended-stay hotels and aparthotels operating on hotel PMSs. Mid-term rental operators show up in the market sizing as out-of-supply-scope (\$24B in the US), and the demand they capture is acknowledged as flowing through channels Mews doesn't own. The Network captures the slice that's structurally suited for Mews's PMS architecture.

Thread: Replicating Sonder's master-lease model

What we considered: Whether the Network should help properties run a Sonder-style master lease arbitrage — Mews properties guarantee inventory to corporate buyers under a master agreement, capturing volume at a discount.

Why we turned it off: Sonder collapsed (November 2025) precisely because master leases proved structurally unprofitable when market conditions shift. The brokerage model is structurally different: Mews doesn't take inventory risk; properties commit availability through their NPA but retain pricing control and can exit any individual booking. The Network captures the broker fee, not the inventory arbitrage.

How the final framing handles it: Mews stays out of the master-lease business entirely. The Network is a programmatic marketplace with NMA + NPA + individual booking three-contract structure. Properties retain operational and pricing control; buyers get programmatic access and consolidated contracting; Mews mediates and monetizes via take rate.

Thread: Building digital keys and access management

What we considered: Adding digital key issuance, smart-lock integrations, and access management to the Resident Platform.

Why we turned it off: Mews already owns this surface via their integrations marketplace (SALTO, ASSA ABLOY, dormakaba, etc.). Building new access management would duplicate existing functionality and consume runway that the brokerage and substrate need. This is a roadmap topic for v2, not a 1.0 dependency.

How the final framing handles it: Digital keys explicitly out of scope. The Resident Portal points residents at the existing Mews digital key flow; the Network doesn't reinvent the access layer.

Thread: Co-tenants, companions, and sub-leasing

What we considered: Modeling co-tenants on a single lease (e.g., travel nurses living together but on separate contracts), companion occupants (spouses, family members), and sub-leasing scenarios.

Why we turned it off: Each of these introduces real complexity (joint and several liability, individual vs. shared deposits, sub-lease consent flows). For v1, the corporate buyer holds the lease and the individual resident is the occupant — one resident per lease. Co-tenancy and sub-leasing become v2 conversations.

How the final framing handles it: Lease has one resident_id and optional buyer_id. Multiple residents staying at the same property under one buyer create N separate leases grouped in a single Mews ReservationGroup. Sub-leasing is explicitly out of scope for 1.0.

Tradeoffs we accepted

Every scoping decision has tradeoffs. The final framing accepts these explicitly rather than pretending they don't exist.

We're choosing US-first over EU-first

Tradeoff: Mews's largest existing customer base is in Europe. EU is Mews's natural home market. By choosing US-first, we're optimizing for the bet where the structural opportunity is largest and most time-sensitive (chain land-grab, Sonder collapse) rather than the market where we have the deepest existing relationships.

Why we accepted it: The US opportunity is structurally larger (\$74B total, \$54B broker-addressable, \$30B Mews-addressable supply) and the supply/demand dislocation is more pronounced. Mews's Series D funding, Dallas hub opening, and AAHOA partnership all signal US prioritization. EU is Phase 2-3, and the same platform architecture supports it — we just don't lead with it.

We're committing to Q3 buyer-side launch even though that's aggressive

Tradeoff: 12 months is aggressive for instantiating a B2B marketplace from zero. Most marketplaces take 18-24 months from greenfield to first transactions. We're claiming buyer-side launch in Q3 (month 9), with healthcare staffing as anchor segment.

Why we accepted it: The supply side already exists (Mews's installed base of long-stay-capable properties). The buyer side is concentrated (top 20 healthcare staffing agencies cover the bulk of US travel-nurse demand). And the brokerage model doesn't require chicken-and-egg liquidity in the marketplace sense — it requires programmatic access to existing supply for a small number of high-value buyers. That's an enterprise sale, not a marketplace bootstrap.

We're putting jurisdictional contract logic in v1 even though it adds scope

Tradeoff: Building jurisdiction-aware contract templates for US-50 + France + Germany + UK is meaningful scope that could be deferred to v2. The temptation is to ship a single generic template and let operators handle local compliance separately.

Why we accepted it: Long-stay leases are jurisdiction-bound by definition — the moment a stay crosses 28-30 days in most US jurisdictions, residential tenancy law applies. Shipping the platform without jurisdiction-aware contracts means every customer hand-rolls their own legal layer, which is exactly the workaround pattern Boost Society and Revisn have already had to build. The contract layer is a substrate feature, not a v2 enhancement.

We're naming five product surfaces but only delivering four in the prototype

Tradeoff: The standalone long-stay booking engine is named as part of 1.0 but isn't in the prototype demo. The risk is that someone in the panel reads this as scope inflation — naming surfaces we haven't built.

Why we accepted it: The corporate booker portal already demonstrates the B2B booking flow. A separate B2C booking engine is conceptually distinct (Tier 1 substrate, property-direct demand) but operationally similar enough that building both for the demo doesn't add proportional information. The roadmap commits to building it; the prototype focuses on the four surfaces that show the network lifecycle happy path most clearly.

Load-bearing assumptions

Three assumptions hold the entire pitch together. The validation plan exists to test these specifically. If any one fails, the framing changes materially.

Assumption 1: Customers will absorb a meaningful add-on price

Claim: Long-stay-heavy Mews customers will pay \$8/unit/month or equivalent because the cost of their current workarounds exceeds the platform price.

Evidence: Boost Society's Hife custom layer almost certainly costs \$400K-\$1M/year in engineering FTE. That's vastly more than \$20-40K of Resident Platform add-on.

Validation: Customer interviews quantify the workaround cost per customer. Field studies at Revisn and Boost identify exactly which workflows justify the price.

If this fails: Price downward and absorb more of the value into the Mews Payments uplift, or position Resident Platform as included in the standard PMS subscription with the Network as the monetization layer.

Assumption 2: Corporate housing buyers will sign an NMA

Claim: Healthcare staffing agencies (anchor segment) will sign a Network Membership Agreement with Mews to access programmatic property inventory.

Evidence: Travel-nurse placements are a multi-billion-dollar housing problem with no incumbent platform. Staffing agencies currently negotiate property by property — every NMA replaces N bilateral contracts. Furnished Finder's 46M nights at 28+ days proves the demand exists; supply quality is the missing piece.

Validation: Buyer-side discovery interviews with 10-15 named healthcare staffing agencies (Aya Healthcare, Cross Country Healthcare, Stanford Healthcare Travel Staffing) test whether the value proposition resonates and what NMA terms would be acceptable.

If this fails: Pivot anchor segment to project workforce (construction, energy, defense) where the buyer concentration is different. Or pivot to corporate mobility (F500 relocations) where the buyer is the F500 mobility lead.

Assumption 3: Properties will commit inventory through an NPA

Claim: Mews-running properties will sign a Network Participation Agreement committing some portion of their long-stay inventory at acceptable rates.

Evidence: Revisn was the first US Mews customer and built their entire business model around Mews long-stay capability — they've stated publicly that they're "betting on Mews to lead this market." Mews's existing CSM organization has direct relationships with these customers.

Validation: Property-side discovery with 15-20 long-stay-heavy Mews customers tests the NPA terms (rate floor, max network exposure, blackout dates) properties would accept.

If this fails: Re-cast the Network as a demand-aggregation channel only (no inventory commitment), where properties opt in per booking. Take rate stays but commitment guarantees go away.

Open questions we'd take to the panel

Honest about what we don't know and would want to discuss in the panel.

- **VP:** Does Mews have current customer data on what % of reservations exceed 28 nights, by enterprise? We assumed roughly 25-40% of properties are long-stay-heavy but we'd want to confirm against the actual distribution.
- **VP:** What's Mews's appetite for Restricted API access to PaymentPlans? Our architecture assumes the Resident Platform team has access (we're internal Mews building this), but we'd want to confirm.
- **VP:** Is there an existing Network-style pilot or partnership conversation we should be aware of? (We don't want to propose something Mews is already six months into.)
- **Product team:** How much overlap is there between the Resident Platform abstraction and Mews's existing exploration of "hybrid hospitality" features?
- **Engineering:** What's the current state of the Mews Connector API on webhooks for the entities we depend on (Bills, PaymentPlans, Companies)? Some webhook gaps may require WebSocket fallback or polling workarounds.
- **Sales:** Who at Mews currently owns the relationships with healthcare staffing agencies? If we're proposing them as anchor segment, we'd want to coordinate with whoever owns those conversations today.

What we'd want to do differently with more time

- **Quantitative analysis:** We rely on triangulated market sizing (Statista, Highland Group, EuroStat, public chain disclosures) for the funnel. With Mews internal data, we'd want to recalibrate against actual Mews customer mix and long-stay reservation distribution.
- **Buyer-side primary research:** We've assumed healthcare staffing as anchor segment based on public Furnished Finder data and industry reports. Direct interviews with 10-15 staffing agency operators would either validate or refine the anchor segment selection.
- **Pricing model validation:** The \$8/unit/month + 5-7% take rate is a planning assumption based on comparable platforms. Real pricing committee discipline (sensitivity analysis, willingness-to-pay tests, anchor pricing) would tighten it.
- **Architecture review:** The façade pattern is well-established but the specific Mews Connector API gaps (webhook coverage, restricted endpoint access) need engineering-team validation before locking the architecture.
- **EU/APAC regional analysis:** We bracketed regional broker-addressable percentages based on global ratios. Country-level analysis would refine the international expansion roadmap.

- Competitive deep-dive: We covered the headline competitive landscape (Sonder collapse, chain land-grab, Stayntouch positioning, Furnished Finder) but didn't go deep on potential entrants from adjacent categories (Stripe Connect, Airbnb For Work, WeWork).

Closing

The thinking moved from "what's the biggest new thing Mews could build" to "what's the biggest new thing Mews could build that's grounded in what existing customers are already telling us is broken." That shift is the central insight.

The Network is the Director-level vision. The Resident Platform substrate is the existing-customer-credibility foundation. The jurisdictional layer is the operational discipline that makes the contract surface real. The validation plan tests the three load-bearing assumptions. The architecture stays composition rather than refactor.

That's the pitch. The journal is what we walked through to get there.